



Primary Education Online · Session 3

Designing for Access in the Primary Classroom

Students come first

Move from understanding to design without turning students into a list of problems.

Start with the real students you have in mind, a specific access question and evidence from the classroom-day map. The design response comes after understanding.

Keep your students in view

Hold a concise picture of each of the students you have in mind, including:

**Strengths, interests
and joy**

**Communication,
sensory experience
and thinking**

**What costs and what
lightens**

Identity and belonging

**What students,
families and the team
already know**

**Questions that remain
open**

You are not building a file on one child. Keep real, different students in view as you design.

Write your brief

Choose one routine you know well, then write an environment-first brief.

This routine asks students to...

For some students, that means...

We could change...

Check the wording: is it specific, workable and free from blame or deficit labels?

Options menu

Four short inputs. Listen for what might answer your brief.

1

Executive functioning supports

Match support to a known demand

2

Predictability

Clear information about routine and change

3

Schedules

Make sequence, timing and change visible

4

Visual supports

Clarify what students need to find, understand, remember or communicate

After the inputs, choose one or two options.

Executive functioning supports across the day

Match support to a known demand:

Make the first step visible

Support holding or sequencing information

Make time and materials easier to organise

Prepare for shifts between tasks

Check usefulness with students rather than assuming the support works.

Predictability in primary education

Predictability includes clear information about routine and change.

Help students answer:



**What is
happening?**



**What is
changing?**



**What comes
next?**



**What can I do if
the plan
changes?**

Give information early enough to be useful.

Schedules: make sequence, timing and change visible. For example, when assembly moves earlier, move its card on the class visual schedule and point it out at the start of the day.

Visual supports

A visual support should clarify something the student needs to find, understand, remember or communicate.

Keep it available at the point of use, avoid unnecessary detail, explain how it works and check its meaning and usefulness with the student.

Quick review of a visual support

- Can the student understand it?
- Can they access it when they need it?
- Does it reflect what is actually happening, including change?
- Does it provide useful information or a way to respond?

Visual Supports Checklist

Online webinar available to explore visual supports in greater depth.

Universal Design for Learning

Apply a Universal Design for Learning lens to the emerging design:

**Make important
information clear and
available**

**Offer workable ways
to participate and
respond**

**Support engagement
without removing
meaningful challenge**

Individual knowledge and universal design can inform each other.

Accessibility check

Run these over your draft design, then test it through use and feedback.

☐ Can students find and understand what they need?

☐ Can they take part in more than one way?

☐ Can they pause, ask for help or recover?

☐ Is the support available when demand increases?

Finish your design

Develop the change in your Participant Guide.

- 1 State the barrier or unnecessary demand.
- 2 Change the environment, task or routine.
- 3 Include students' communication and experience.
- 4 Decide what you will observe.
- 5 Set a time to review.

In a breakout pair, check the design remains student-centred.

Check the design against your students

Privately, test your design against each of your students.

	Helps	No difference	Needs something more
Student A			
Student B			
Student C			

Where the design still doesn't work for someone, that is where targeted or individual support begins.

Continuum of support

Support is a continuum rather than a single intervention.

1

Inclusive environment

First, design inclusive environments that reduce barriers for everyone.

2

Universal supports

Then, provide universal supports that many students may benefit from.

3

Targeted supports

Next, offer targeted supports for students who need additional assistance.

4

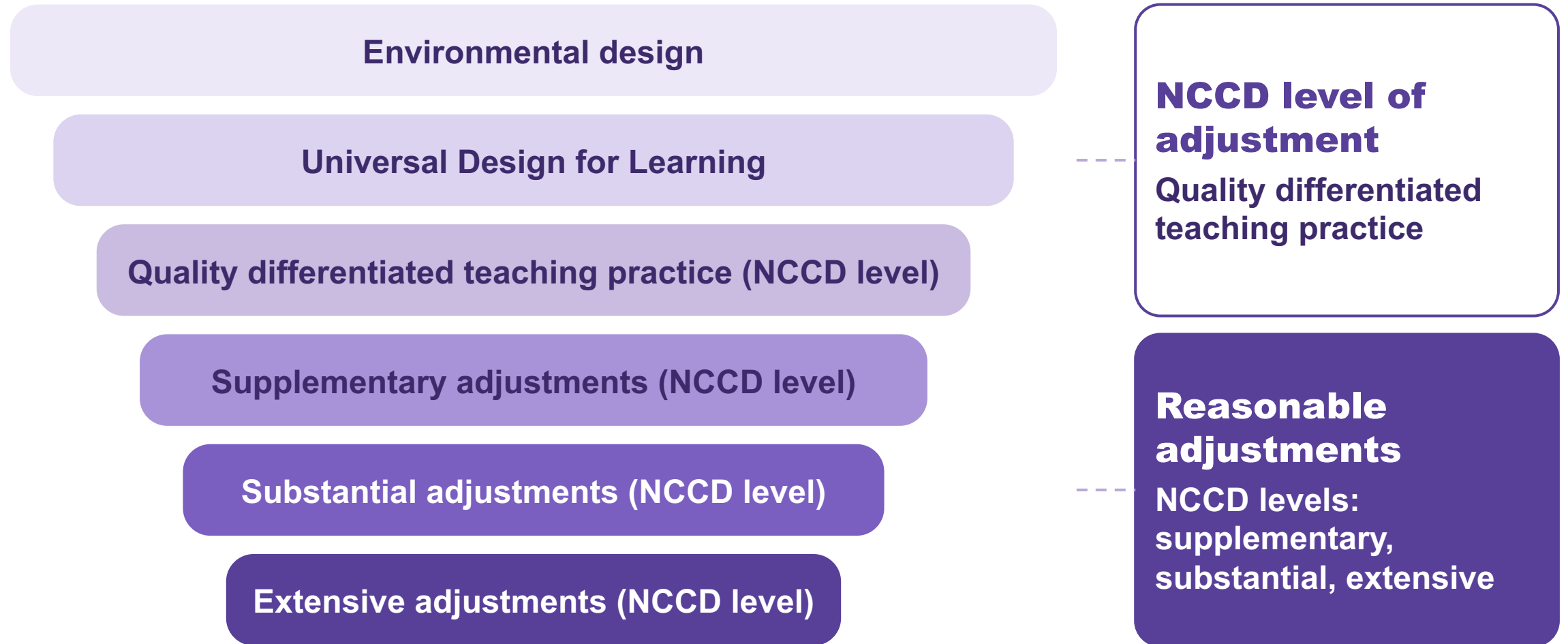
Individual adjustments

Finally, where necessary, implement individual adjustments to ensure equitable access, participation and learning.

Academic adjustments sit within a wider continuum of support.

Consider what is available to everyone, what is targeted and what is individually adjusted. Each response should connect to access and participation needs and be reviewed through use and feedback.

Reasonable Adjustments



NCCD

NCCD information and links

Connect the NCCD discussion with reasonable adjustments and evidence. Follow the consultation, documentation and review processes used in your school or system, and make responsibilities clear to the student, family and staff involved.

Under the Disability Standards for Education 2005, schools must consult the student, or an associate such as a parent or carer, about adjustments.

Share, refine and commit



Before you leave, ask yourself:

- What will you try?
- What will you notice?
- Who needs to be involved?
- How will students and families help refine it?

Treat the change as something to try, review and refine.